Paul’s Prayer for the Colossians

Paul prays that believers will be filled with the knowledge of God’s will so they may walk worthy of the Lord — a walk seen in fruit, growth, joyful endurance and thanks to the Father who qualified, rescued, transferred and redeemed them.

Where this study fits

Colossians · twelve studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–8 **Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae**	**02 1:9–14** **Paul's Prayer for the Colossians**	**03 1:15–23** **The Savior of the Gospel**	**04 1:24–29** **Christ in You, the Hope of Glory**
05 2:1–7 **The Believer's Education**	**06 2:8–15** **Beware of Philosophy**	**07 2:16–23** **Run the Race Set Before You**	**08 3:1–11** **Looking Up, Putting Off**
09 3:12–17 **Service Manual for the Lord's Army**	**10 3:18–4:1** **The Relationships of the New Man**	**11 4:2–6** **Perfecting the Prayer Life**	**12 4:7–18** **Portrait of a Ministry Team**

Paul’s prayer as a building

Colossians 1:9–14 · The commentary’s outline

I. The foundation	II. The superstructure	III. The outer part
ἐπίγνωσις Filled with the knowledge of His will, in all spiritual wisdom and understanding	**περιπατέω** A walk worthy of the Lord, pleasing Him in all respects	What people see: fruit, growth, power to endure, and thanksgiving
v.9	v.10a	vv.10b–14

Knowledge is never an end in itself. The goal of knowing God’s will is doing it.

Three words for one need

Colossians 1:9 · Outline I.B — The foundation: knowledge

1 Knowledge

ἐπίγνωσις epignōsis · G1922
Full, accurate, personal knowledge — the false teachers boasted of gnōsis; Paul prays for epi-gnōsis

2 Wisdom

σοφία sophia · G4678
The skill to use that knowledge in real life, including the discernment to spot error

3 Understanding

σύνεσις synesis · G4907
To "bring things together" — set each error beside the Scripture that refutes it

✓ "Filled" · "spiritual"

πληρόω Aor. Pass. Subj.
Not something added from outside — filled with what God has revealed, by the Spirit

The best defense against counterfeit knowledge is full, accurate knowledge of God's will.

Already accepted — so we aim to please

Colossians 1:10a · Outline II — The superstructure: a worthy walk

What the walk is not

Not the price of eternal life

Not currying favor to get accepted (the old sense of areskeia)

Not striving for a status we lack

vs

What the walk is
ἀρεσκεία areskeia · “to please”

The fitting response to a gift already received

Delighting the Lord “in all respects” — every area of life

A life that matches the worth of the Lord we represent

Already saints, qualified, rescued and redeemed (1:2, 12–14) — the worthy walk flows from acceptance, never toward it.

What people see: four marks of a worthy walk

Colossians 1:10b–12 · Outline III — The outer part

v.10b	Bearing fruit in every good work — the fruitful gospel (v.6) produces fruitful people	**καρποφορέω** same verb as v.6
v.10c	Increasing in the knowledge of God — knowledge leads to obedience, obedience to deeper knowledge	**ἐπίγνωσις** growth by the Word
v.11	Strengthened with all power, according to His glorious might — not for show, but for go	**δυναμόω** Pres. Pass. — a continuous supply
v.11	Steadfastness — “remaining under” pressures, persecutions and temptations	**ὑπομονή** toward circumstances
v.11	Patience — “long-tempered” restraint that refuses to retaliate	**μακροθυμία** toward people
v.12	Joyously giving thanks to the Father	**εὐχαριστέω** endurance with joy

Four things the Father has already done

Colossians 1:12–14 · Outline III.D — Giving thanks to the Father

1	**He qualified us — v.12** Made us fit to share in the inheritance of the saints in Light. We did not qualify ourselves.	**ἱκανόω** Aor. — done
2	**He rescued us — v.13a** Drew us out of “the domain of darkness,” a realm ruled by a tyrant	**ῥύομαι** to rescue, draw to oneself
3	**He transferred us — v.13b** Relocated us to the kingdom of His beloved Son: a new address and a new King	**μεθίστημι** to resettle a people
4	**He redeemed us — v.14** Release by payment of a price — “the forgiveness of sins,” sins sent away	**ἀπολύτρωσις** ransom-release

The false teachers wanted believers to strive for a status they already had. Paul wants them to enjoy it and give thanks.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 1:9–14 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How does Paul become part of the answer to his own prayer, and what does that suggest for us?

2. Distinguish “steadfastness” from “patience” in verse 11. Where do you need each right now?

Apply

Upgrade Your Prayer List
Choose three people and pray verses 9–12 for them by name every day this week.

Give Thanks for What Is Already Done
Read verses 12–14 aloud each day and thank God for each of the four gifts by name.

In one line: Pray for knowledge that becomes a worthy walk — anchored in what the Father has already done.